NITISH SPREADSHEET

TRIPLED SOCIAL SECURITY: From Rs 400 to Rs 1,100 per month for elderly, disabled, and widowed

DEARNESS ALOWANCE HIKE: Raised for over 1.1 million government employees and pensioners

JOB DRIVE: Appointment letters distributed to 21,391 police constables on June 18

JEEVIKA EMPOWERMENT: Honorarium doubled for 140,000 SHG workers; loan interest above Rs 3 lakh reduced from 10% to 7%

MAHILA SAMVAD: Outreach targeting 37.25 million women voters across Bihar

RELIGIOUS INFRASTRUCTURE: Grand redevelopment of Sita's birthplace at Sitamarhi under a government trust

PANCHAYAT PAY HIKE: Allowances raised for mukhiyas, sarpanches, ward members

that's not likely to stop the salvos from Nitish. Patna is awash with his pledges, a blitz as variegated as Bihar itself: jobs for youth, temples for the devout, hiked dearness allowance for over 1.1 million public employees and pensioners, doubled pay for rural women in the Jeevika workforce, higher stipend for panchayat leaders, besides the fattened pension cheques for senior citizens.

Nitish knows jobs are the biggest pain point for young voters, who fill out one-third of Bihar's electorate. His promised cornucopia projects 3.4 million new jobs, formal and informal, by next year—a rosy prognosis meant to soften any anger on the street. Over 500,000 government posts have been filled, he says, with recruitment ongoing for another 200,000. Besides, a new internship scheme, aimed at skilling youth aged 18–28, offers monthly stipends of Rs 4,000 to Rs 6,000.

The mukhiya and sarpanch form another force-multiplying cohort. In Bihar's intricate web of local power, winning them over often means securing the support of dozens of families. Their honorariums have been raised by 150 per cent, with an annual budget of Rs 548 crore earmarked for it. To top up, the panchayat head's sanction limit under NREGA was upped from Rs 500,000 to Rs 1 million in June.



CROWNED OPPONENT RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav in Patna, Jun. 29

WOMEN FIRST

Bihar's 37 million women form 47.8 per cent of its electorate. It's Nitish's old piggy bank, but Tejashwi has promised Rs 2,500 for girls' education this time. So, a new cupid's arrow had to be fashioned. Ergo the hiked honorariums and cheaper loans for the Jeevika self-help workforce, and the paternalistic offer of new marriage halls in all 8,053 gram panchayats. A grand temple at Sitamarhi rounds off the vision. As Bihar chooses its groom by *swayamvar*, Nitish aims to be the handsome victor. ■

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

IN KANPUR, A TOP OFFICIAL IS THROWN OUT of a meeting hall by another, then caught on tape hurling abuses. In Banda, a ruling party MLA allegedly slaps a babu who dared to seize trucks linked to illegal mining. In Lucknow, a minister from BJP ally Apna Dal (Sonelal), Ashish Patel, accuses senior officials of conspiring to damage his political career—as also that of his wife, Union minister Anupriya Patel—and dares the state's Special Task Force to "shoot him in the chest".

What exactly is happening in Uttar Pradesh, with this flurry of public clashes between its netas and bureaucrats, spilling over into viral videos, FIRs and noisy social media battles? An unlikely monsoon shower of contretemps for the BJP, that too in a showpiece state, it points to deeper strains that are all but bursting through the subsoil.

PUBLIC SQUABBLE

Kanpur was the latest flashpoint. Here, Chief Medical Officer (CMO) Hari Dutt Nemi was suspended on June 20 after a prolonged and very public feud with District Magistrate (DM) Jitendra Pratap Singh. The suspended CMO called a press conference to accuse the DM of pressurising him to carry out "illegal work". The DM, in turn, wrote to the government accusing Nemi of corruption, misconduct and manipulating transfers. Audio clips surfaced where Nemi is allegedly heard mocking the DM's long speeches; he later claimed the clips were AI-generated.

The administrative spat soon spiralled into a political slugfest; BJP leaders openly took sides. Speaker Satish Mahana, BJP